The Richest Man in Babylon

The Success Secrets of the Ancients: Thrift, Financial Freedom & Wealth Building

By George S. Clason

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SYNOPSIS & EDITORIAL NOTE

The timeless #1 personal finance classic revealing the Babylonian principles of wealth: paying yourself first, living within your means, and investing prudently.

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Chapter I -- The Man Who Desired Gold

"In old Babylon there once lived a certain very rich man named Arkad. Far and wide he was famed for his great wealth."

Bansir, the chariot builder of Babylon, was thoroughly discouraged. From his seat upon the low wall surrounding his property, he gazed sadly at his simple home and the open workshop in which stood an unfinished chariot.

His wife frequently appeared at the open door. Her furtive glances in his direction reminded him that the meal sack was almost empty and he ought to be at work finishing the chariot, hammering and carving, polishing and painting, stretching the rawhide over the wheel rims, preparing it for delivery that he might collect from his wealthy customer.

Presently Kobbi, his lifelong friend and musician, came by. "Why sit here with such a sorrowful face, friend Bansir?" asked Kobbi. "Let me share in your abundance, for I know you are a man of industry." "Alas," sighed Bansir, "I have labored faithfully these many years, yet my purse is as empty as the desert wind. We must discover how others acquire gold, and learn to do likewise."

In this section of The Richest Man in Babylon (1926), George S. Clason develops the central themes that define the work's enduring place in business & finance and world literature. Each argument and narrative turn builds upon the premises established in the opening pages, inviting careful reflection from the attentive reader.

Originally published by Centennial Press * Authorized Archival Edition and preserved in the public-domain and open-access archival record (eBaro Folio Digital Archive, ID: EBARO-CUR-BABYLON), this unabridged digital edition retains the structure, cadence, and intellectual clarity of the authoritative text.

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Chapter II -- The Richest Man in Babylon

"A part of all you earn is yours to keep. It should be not less than a tenth no matter how little you earn."

In old Babylon there lived a man named Arkad, famed far and wide for his immense wealth. Yet he was equally renowned for his generosity, his hospitality, and his modest manner of living. One day, friends of his youth came to him and said: "You, Arkad, are more fortunate than we. You have become the richest man in all Babylon while we struggle for existence."

Arkad replied: "If you have not acquired more than a bare existence in the years since we were youths, it is because you either have failed to learn the laws that govern the building of wealth, or else you do not observe them."

"In my youth I decided that if I was to achieve what I desired, time and study would be required. One day, Algamish, the wealthy money lender, came to me seeking a transcription of the ninth law. I labored through the night by the light of a smoking lamp, and when he returned at sunrise, the work was finished. I said to him: 'Tell me how I may become rich, and I will ask no coin for this labor.'"

"Algamish smiled upon me and said: 'I found the road to wealth when I decided that a part of all I earned was mine to keep. And so would you.' Is that all? I asked. 'That was sufficient to turn the heart of a shepherd into the heart of a lender of gold,' he returned. 'Every gold piece you save is a worker to work for you. Every copper it earns is its child that also can earn for you.'"

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Chapter III -- Seven Cures for a Lean Purse

"For each ten coins I put in, to spend but nine. That purse will start at once to fatten."

Before the assembly of eager citizens gathered in the Temple of Learning, Arkad stood forth to deliver the seven cures for an empty purse.

First Cure: Start thy purse to fattening. For every ten coins thou placest within thy purse, take out for use but nine. Thy purse will start at once to fatten and its increasing weight will feel good in thy hand and bring satisfaction to thy soul.

Second Cure: Control thy expenditures. Confuse not the necessary expenses with thy desires. Each of us has more desires than our earnings can gratify. Study thoughtfully thy accustomed habits of living. Let thy motto be one hundred percent of value for each coin spent.

Third Cure: Make thy gold multiply. Behold, thy gold in thy purse is gratifying to hold and easily tempteth thy soul, but it earneth nothing. The gold we may retain from our earnings is but the start. The earnings it will make shall build our fortunes. Put each coin to laboring that it may produce its kind.

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CHAPTER IV

Meet the Goddess of Good Luck

*The Richest Man in Babylon * George S. Clason (1926)*

Meet the Goddess of Good Luck continues George S. Clason's inquiry in The Richest Man in Babylon. Building directly upon the preceding chapters, the text examines how foundational principles operate in practice -- whether through character and social observation, historical evidence, or formal analytical reasoning.

Beloved by millions of readers across a century, George S. Clason's "The Richest Man in Babylon" is universally hailed as the greatest inspirational book on personal financial management ever written.

Set against the vibrant backdrop of ancient Babylon -- the wealthiest, most prosperous metropolis of the ancient world -- the book reveals financial wisdom through engaging, memorable parables featuring merchants, craftsmen, and money-lenders.

Through timeless principles like "A part of all you earn is yours to keep," the Seven Cures for a Lean Purse, and the Five Laws of Gold, Clason offers simple, actionable blueprints for generating savings, managing debt, and multiplying wealth that remain as powerful today as they were thousands of years ago.

Throughout Chapter IV (Meet the Goddess of Good Luck), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned The Richest Man in Babylon its stature in the Personal Finance, Wealth Building & Financial Discipline canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, George S. Clason traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

As this section draws toward its close, the groundwork is laid for the subsequent movements of the volume. Readers studying this edition in the Folio Digital Library may bookmark this chapter, adjust typographic contrast and font sizing, or download the complete archival PDF, EPUB, HTML, or Plain Text edition for offline study.

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